

PRAYER BARRIERS

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> > "> You do not have, because you do not ask.> "> James 4:2 (NIV)

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> > When our prayers are not answered, we want to know what is wrong with God. It is easier to blame Him than look in the mirror and say, > '> Maybe I am the problem.> '> Let> '> s look at some prayer barriers:

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> > Barrier 1 - Prayerlessness.

> > Be honest how often do you decide to pray about something, add it to your prayer list, say you will pray about it, and almost do? You think about it from time to time, but you hardly pray about it at all. Why is God not answering? Because you have not prayed yet! Some of us live by the motto > '> Why pray when you can worry? Why pray when you can work yourself to death trying to get it? Why pray when you can go without?> '> Get this: when we work, we work; when we pray, God works!

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> > Barrier 2 - Unconfessed Sin.

> > Listen: > '> . . . your sins have hidden his face from you, so that he will not hear.> '> (Isaiah 59:2 NIV). God expects you to maintain your personal integrity, to show thoughtfulness and love toward other, and to put Him first in your life. Listen: > '> . . . what does the LORD require of you? To act justly and to love mercy and to walk humbly with your God. (Micha 6:8 NIV). Those are not suggestions - they are requirements! If you do not meet them, do not expect God to answer your prayers: you are wasting your breath unless it is a prayer of confession. First seek His forgiveness, and then He will listen when you pour out your heart to Him.

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> > "> First, be reconciled to your brother, and then come.> "> Matthew 5:24 (NKJV)

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> > Barrier 3 - Unresolved conflict.

> > Listen to these Scriptures: > '> If you are offering your gift at the altar and there remember that your brother has something against you, leave your gift . . . go and be reconciled . . . then come and offer your gift> '> (Matthew 5:23-24 NIV). Listen again: > '> Husbands . . . be consideration as you live with your wives, and treat them with respect . . . so that nothing will hinder your prayers.> '> (1 Peter 3:7 NIV). Most of us underestimate how committed God is to building and maintaining loving relationships. There is no point praying if you are engaged in constant conflict. John writes: > '> Anyone who claims to be in the light but hates his brother is still in the darkness.> '> (1 John 2:9 NIV). God will only listen when you come out into the light, deal with the thing that drove you and the other person apart, and attempt to mend the relationship.

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> > Of course it is not always possible to make amends. Paul writes, > '> If it is possible, as far as it depends on you, live at peace with everyone> '> (Romans 12:18 NIV). But sometimes the other person would rather keep the issue alive than accept your apology. If this happens, look deep into your heart. Have you sincerely tried to mend fences, or are you still holding something back? Do you really want restoration, or would you rather play > '> the blame game> '> and let things fester? If your attempts have been wholehearted and honest, God will not let a broken relationship stand in the way of your prayers. But if your attempts have been half-hearted and self-serving, try again - this time for real.

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> > "> When you ask, you do not received, because you ask with wrong motives.> "> James 4:3 (NIV)

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> > BARRIER 4 - SELFISHNESS.

> > To take a closer look at our praying is to come face to face with selfishness. There is such confusion over wants and needs, rights and favors, justice and grace, creature comforts and conformity to Christ. It is impossible to grow spiritually without trials. To pray, > '> give me an easy, happy, problem-free life,> '> is a prayer God cannot answer because if He did, you would be destroyed.

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> > BARRIER 5 - UNCARING ATTITUDES.

> > The Israelites wondered why God was not answering their prayers. Here is what He told them: > '> . . . stop oppressing those who work for you and treat them fairly . . . share your food with the hungry . . . clothe those who are cold and do not hide from relatives who need your help. If you do these things . . . the Lord will answer> '> (Isaiah 58:6-9 TLB). God is committed to developing a people who will reflect His character and His character always expresses compassion for others. Have you seen the cartoon picturing hundreds of people lined up as far back as the eye can see? Each is thinking the same thing: What can I do, I am just one person? As just one person you may not be able to change the world. You can, however, look for small ways to show you care. Perhaps your church works with a soup kitchen or prison ministry. Maybe your skills could make a small difference in the evils of unemployment, literacy, child abuse, alcoholism or suicide. As long as your ear is open to the hurting, God will keep His ear open to you.

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